

Stay Alive, My Son Chapter 1 & 2

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ABSTRACT

This abstract provides an overview of the immersive and interactive experience titled "Stay Alive, My Son Chapter 1 & 2" [Bousis 2021] which is based on the memoirs of Pin Yathay [Pin 2000], a survivor of the Cambodian genocide. The abstract summarizes the narrative structure, technological aspects, and thematic significance of the project. Additionally, it highlights the transformative journey of the audience, the utilization of virtual human creation technology, and the director's vision to evoke empathy and inspire change.

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1 INTRODUCTION

The immersive experience "Stay Alive, My Son Chapter 1 & 2" is inspired by true events and the memoirs of Pin Yathay [Pin 2000] (see Figure 1), a Cambodian genocide survivor [Sean 2009].

It aims to break the conventions of traditional storytelling by utilizing advanced technology to create an interactive and emotionally engaging narrative. The experience enables the audience to step into the shoes of Yathay and confront the anguish caused by a decision that continues to haunt him. By immersing the audience in Yathay's mental prison, the experience delves into pivotal moments leading to his decision and explores the historical context of Cambodia (see Figure 2, Figure 3, and Figure 4).

2 DESIGN AND IMPLEMENTATION

To bring "Stay Alive, My Son Chapter 1 & 2" to life, the project utilizes cutting-edge technology, particularly metahuman creation [Fang et al. 2021] in virtual reality. Developed by UME Studios, a unique pipeline is employed to create a realistic digital representation of Pin Yathay (see Figure 5).

The metahuman model comprises intricate rigging systems with a multitude of bones, facilitating fluid movements and realistic facial expressions. The attention to detail extends to clothing, which undergoes physics simulations to enhance its authenticity. Through the integration of artificial intelligence, the interactions between the audience and the digital Yathay are heightened, fostering strong emotional connections (see Figure 6).

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Figure 1: Book Cover of Yathay Pin's Memoirs - "Tu vivras, mon fils"



Figure 2: In Experience, Outside Yathay's House in Paris.



Figure 3: In Experience Inside Yathay's Mental Prison.

3 CHALLENGES

The development of "Stay Alive, My Son Chapter 1 & 2" presents various challenges that need to be addressed to deliver an immersive and impactful experience. One of the primary challenges lies



Figure 4: In Experience Angkor Wat Temple.



Figure 5: Real Live (L) and Metahuman (R) Yathay Pin.



Figure 6: Yathay's Body and Face Rig (L), and Metahuman Full Body Shot with Clothing (R).

in accurately representing Yathay's story and trauma while respecting the historical context and cultural sensitivity surrounding the Cambodian genocide. Extensive research and collaboration with survivors and experts were undertaken to ensure the fidelity of the narrative.

Furthermore, the technical implementation of the project required a high level of expertise in metahuman creation and virtual reality. UME Studios pioneered pipelines for customizing characters, allowing them to resemble real people within virtual environments. The complexity of rigging systems, including thousands of bones,

necessitated meticulous animation and physics simulations for natural movements and realistic interactions.

Ethical considerations were also paramount throughout the development process [IEEE 2022]. Ensuring the responsible and respectful representation of Yathay's story, trauma, and the broader historical events was of utmost importance. Extensive care was taken to approach the subject matter with sensitivity and empathy, aiming to foster understanding and inspire positive change.

4 CONCLUSION

"Stay Alive, My Son Chapter 1 & 2" is an immersive and interactive experience that seeks to transcend traditional storytelling and provide audiences with an emotional and transformative journey. Using advanced technology and the depiction of Pin Yathay's memoirs, the project aims to evoke empathy and inspire positive action. By stepping into Yathay's shoes and confronting his past, audiences are encouraged to challenge narratives surrounding family separation and become advocates for unity and justice. The successful implementation of the project required overcoming challenges related to narrative fidelity, technical complexities, and ethical considerations, resulting in a powerful and thought-provoking experience.

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